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Red-bellied Woodpecker

*Melanerpes carolinus***QUICK STATS**

Length	9.4 in (24 cm)
Wingspan	13.0 – 16.5 in (33 – 42 cm)
Weight	2.0 – 3.2 oz (56 – 91 g)
Lifespan	Up to 12 years (avg. 2–3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

Despite its name, the Red-bellied Woodpecker's most striking feature is its brilliant red cap — not its belly, which shows only a faint reddish wash that is rarely visible in the field. This bold, vocal woodpecker has expanded dramatically northward over the past century, colonizing new areas of the northeastern United States and southern Canada as forests have matured. With its ladder-backed black-and-white barring and loud, rolling "churr" call, it is one of the most conspicuous and entertaining birds at suet feeders across eastern North America. Its remarkably long, barbed tongue — extending up to 2 inches beyond the bill — allows it to extract insects from deep bark crevices and remove seeds from tight spaces.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Red-bellied Woodpecker is found year-round across the eastern United States, from southern Canada south to Florida and west to the Great Plains. It inhabits mature deciduous and mixed forests, forest edges, suburban parks, and wooded gardens with large trees. It shows a preference for oak-dominated forests where acorns are plentiful, but readily adapts to suburban environments wherever there are large, established trees. It is a permanent resident throughout its range and does not migrate.

DIET & FEEDING

- Suet cakes — the top feeder attraction for this species
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and sunflower chips
- Whole and shelled peanuts
- Acorns and beechnuts (cached in bark crevices)
- Insects and larvae extracted from dead wood
- Wild berries and small fruits — especially in autumn

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Red-bellied Woodpeckers are bold, assertive birds at feeders, often dominating smaller species such as Downy Woodpeckers and nuthatches. They are year-round residents that maintain fixed territories, defended loudly with calls and drumming. Like other woodpeckers, they are avid food cachers — storing seeds, acorns, and insects in bark crevices, post holes, and even the gaps in wooden siding. Their long, sticky tongue is specially adapted to extract prey from deep crevices, and their stiff tail feathers act as a prop against tree trunks. They often join mixed foraging flocks with chickadees and nuthatches in winter.

NESTING & BREEDING

Red-bellied Woodpeckers excavate nest cavities in dead or dying trees, typically at heights of 5–70 feet. The male does most of the excavation, taking 1–2 weeks to complete the cavity. Both parents incubate the 4–5 white eggs for 12 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 24–27 days. The species raises 2–3 broods per season. Old cavities are frequently reused in subsequent years and provide critical nesting sites for secondary cavity nesters such as Eastern Bluebirds and screech-owls.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Red-bellied Woodpecker is one of the most vocal woodpeckers in eastern North America. Its primary call is a loud, rolling "churr" or "kwirr" that carries clearly through the forest. It also gives a sharp "chek" alarm call and a variety of softer conversational notes between mates. Drumming on resonant dead wood or metal surfaces serves as a territorial advertisement, with rapid, sustained bursts that can be heard from considerable distances.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Increasing
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The Red-bellied Woodpecker has been one of the great conservation success stories of recent decades. Once largely confined to the southeastern United States, it has expanded its range steadily northward since the mid-20th century, benefiting from forest maturation, milder winters, and the proliferation of backyard feeders. Its population is estimated at approximately 16 million individuals and continues to grow.

FEEDER TIPS

- Mount a suet cage directly on a tree trunk — ideal positioning for this species
- Offer whole peanuts in a mesh peanut feeder
- Large hopper or platform feeders with sunflower seeds attract them readily
- Install a nest box with a 2-inch entrance hole on a large dead snag
- Red-bellied Woodpeckers cache food — expect them to make repeated quick visits

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown (male)	Full red cap — forehead to nape
Crown (female)	Red on nape only; gray forehead
Back & wings	Bold black-and-white barring
Face & underparts	Pale gray-buff
Belly patch	Faint red-orange wash (often hidden)
Bill	Long, chisel-tipped, dark gray

COLOR ME!

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